

Oversharing

Social media can be a useful tool for teens to establish friendships, and share memories and thoughts. But sometimes these shared thoughts can cross the line into “too much information.” Most people have read a post or viewed an image uploaded online by a friend, and cringed at the intimate details that have been shared with the world. Being too honest, or “oversharing,” can have consequences. All information posted online remains online, and if inappropriate or hurtful comments are made, relationships can be damaged as a result.

PARENT TIPS

Lead by example

Parents can help their teens to feel comfortable in what they are posting by speaking to them about oversharing, and by modeling appropriate social media content in their own posts.

- Show your teen how your profile is set to private in order to limit who can view posts, and help them set theirs, too.
- Remember that as a parent, your teen is unlikely to appreciate you sharing embarrassing photos or too much information about them online.

Avatars

In video games, avatars are three-dimensional electronic images that represent the player in the game and interact with other elements of the game. Based on the gaming avatars, two-dimensional avatars are increasingly used on social media platforms, so that users have a visual representation of themselves without needing to use a photograph. Using an avatar instead of a photograph gives people more control over their digital footprints and the information that they are sharing with people.



△ **Unintentional clues**
Photos can give away clues to a person's identity, such as their hobbies and places they like to go.



△ **Unique but anonymous**
Teens can still show their personality through an avatar without revealing any personal information.

Digital footprints

A person's online activities leave a trail, commonly called a “digital footprint.” It's a record of everything that they do on digital devices. Sometimes users intentionally leave their information online, such as through social media, but it's possible to unintentionally do this, too. Data about a person and their Internet usage and activity may be collected by websites without a person knowing. It is increasingly common for employers and universities to “cyber vet” people to make sure that their online history doesn't have any objectionable or potentially embarrassing content.

GOOD TO KNOW

Cookies

Cookies are small text files that are created when a person visits a website, and record what that person did while on that website. These cookies download onto the person's computer ready for the next time they visit the same site. On future visits, the cookie sends information back to the website, allowing the site to tailor information that pops up based on what the user browsed and clicked on during their previous visit. Cookies also record what site a person navigated from, what ads they saw, and what site they went to afterward—information that can be used to build up a profile of a person's online actions.